

“Hold on with a **bulldog grip**,
and **chew and choke** as much
as possible.”

ABRAHAM LINCOLN IN A TELEGRAM TO ULYSSES S. GRANT, AUGUST 17,
1864

Railroads and a cattle raid

Grant redoubled his efforts around the armies' edges, seeking to thin the Confederate lines until they broke. On August 18–21, Major General Gouverneur K. Warren's Fifth Corps seized another of Lee's arteries to the south. In the Battle of the Weldon Railroad, troops of General A. P. Hill's Third Corps slammed into Warren's, forcing them into open fields. There the Union infantry held, despite Hill's assaults—and held the railroad too.

Loss of the Weldon Railroad raised the specter of starvation for Lee's soldiers. In mid-September, General Wade Hampton and 4,000 troopers rode around the Army of the Potomac, almost as far as Grant's supply depot at City Point. They raided the Union cattle corral, rustling some 2,000 head and, driving the herd back, lost only 60 men.

That fall, Grant continued his war of maneuver. On September 29–30, Union forces took Fort Harrison, a key bastion in the Richmond defenses, helped by an attack on Confederate positions above New Market Road, for which 14 Black soldiers were awarded Medals of Honor. At the same time, on the other end of the line, a Union reconnaissance force pushed 3 miles (5km) west of the Weldon Railroad, only to be beaten back by A. P. Hill and Wade Hampton in a brutal two-day fight at Peebles' Farm.

On October 27, Grant's Second Corps and part of his Fifth Corps, with a cavalry screen, reached out even farther west in an attempt to cut the Boydton Plank Road, an important link to the southwest. By exploiting a gap between the two corps, the Confederates